
4. How much to buy?

This sounds like a simple question until you start factoring in all the variables for you and your various family members. The three main factors I like to consider when making these decisions are:

1. Consumption rate. Usage patterns will vary per person and item.
2. Available storage space.
- 3 Your specific situation (financial goals, available cash, other monetary priorities).

While you'll need to work out the actual amounts for yourself, considering the above factors that are unique to your home should help guide you.

5. Challenges and strategies

Carving out the up-front cash

If you're having trouble finding the extra \$2 for bus fare, setting aside funds for bulk shopping can be pretty daunting.

It's okay to start small. Bulk toiletries such as large-quantity bottles of shampoo provide an excellent value for your start-up dollar, as do beans and rice. To get the biggest bang for your bulk-buying buck, however, my money's on yeast and spices. Use the extra funds saved from

those purchases to make a few more precision purchases with each new shopping trip. While you won't be super-stocked overnight, it will add up over time, and you will eventually be in the driver's seat.

Staying focused and making It a priority

Some folks have a hard time avoiding feelings of discouragement and deprivation. How do you set yourself up for success? One strategy is to choose start-up bulk items with a high personal "wow factor" or a huge initial savings return. Then, combine this strategy with short-term financial goals you can easily accomplish with the savings you achieve. Being able to get excited about the initial returns will go a long way toward staying committed for the long haul.

Getting (and staying) organized

This is a challenge shared by nearly everyone, regardless of the amount of space, storage infrastructure, and start-up cash available. Start small and pace yourself. You want to be able to get a handle on the situation, as well as stay on top of the new system. Bulk buying is one of those concepts that sounds simple until you start trying to implement it across the board, and realize all of the "sub-issues" that come along with it, not the least of which is figuring out where to put everything you just brought home.